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Stanley Dance

The writing of Stanley Dance has been a part of the jazz scene since the early 1930s. He was born in Braintree, England on September 15, 1910, and was attracted to American jazz by searching out the recordings that made their way to England and France. His first articles appeared in Jazz Hot *and he traveled to the U.S. in 1937. Jazz lovers grew familiar with his articles and critiques as his work appeared in* Down Beat, Metronome, *the* Jazz Journal, *the* New York Herald Tribune, *and many other publications. His series of books entitled* The World of ... *included definitive studies of the bands of Count Basie, Earl Hines, Duke Ellington and swing music as a whole. Stanley has produced recordings for Columbia, Black Lion and RCA Camden, and he and his wife Helen became close personal friends and confidants of Duke Ellington. His work has been honored numerous times, including the 1979 Deems Taylor ASCAP Award.*

Stanley was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 12, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive, in San Diego. It's quite an honor for me to be talking with Stanley Dance, one of our most noted authors and jazz critics and historians. I'm always curious how a gentleman from England, you were growing up in the '20s — what was it that captured your ear?

SD: Well radio of course. You'd hear jazz of the time on the radio. Then by a lucky chance, my father sent me away to a boarding school, where the sons of several of the directors of the leading record companies were also sent. Now these kids came back each term with all the records. Most kids brought back the records they liked, which was the pop records, and you'd be sick of them you know after two or three times. But these kids would have weird records by Jelly Roll Morton and his Hot Peppers. We were very fond of another one called Bobby Lechens Leidmore Band, which was a washboard band. We had Red Nichols and his Five Pennies and so forth and so on. These records were, at the beginning of the term were not played because people put them on and would say, "I don't like that." But after three or four weeks of the pop hits you were sick of them. And then various people would put these strange records on. And the school was divided into four houses. And each house had a room for entertainment. And in each of them as I remember there would be some boys that would be attracted to this music. Sometimes for rather strange reasons. I remember that Benny Moten's band in Kansas City made a record called "Thick Lip Stomp." And there was one boy that had thick lips. He wasn't black or Negro as we said at that time at all, but he was known as Thick Lip Liggert. And when they found this record, "Thick Lip Stomp," every time he came in the room

from this grew a sort of more intelligent interest in music. There was, early on in England there was the paper called *The Melody Maker* which had record reviews which were fairly hip. But the influence in England to begin with was mainly coming from, well very often came from New York musicians who were playing in The Savoy Hotel and places like that. They came over and they were full of we'll say Red Nichols, Joe Venuti, Ed Lang and people like that. But the black musicians were considered, for a long time, somewhat crude. And it wasn't until I guess almost 1930 that we began to discover this music with a little more serious intent. And then — there was nevertheless quite a big interest in jazz in England, as in France. And then the musicians started to come over — Louis Armstrong came, Fats Waller came, and then in 1933 Duke Ellington came. And that later became my main thing. That was unquestionably the biggest sensation any jazz group ever made in England. They played at The Palladium, which was a sort of vaudeville house. And they would play a set of about 40 minutes or so. And that was not enough for the audience. The musicians knew of Ellington by then, and there was a big clamor for better presentation. And *The Melody Maker* organized two concerts in The Trocadero, which was the biggest movie house in Europe. And it was packed and jammed. And the first concert was sold out, and Duke knew they wanted to hear what they called the real thing you know. They didn't want to hear "Stormy Weather" again. They wanted to hear his compositions. They played an excellent program. At the second concert he couldn't really believe it. He'd compromised a bit. He played some of the more popular things. But that was a sensation. They looked very smart, they were well dressed in sort of light colored, fawn colored suits as I remember, with orange ties — and you know we just thought that looked very, very — in fact, many of his fans wore orange ties for quite a long time after that. Well I really only said hello to Duke on that occasion. But then I remember meeting, somehow or other, Fats Waller when he was there, and that was very instructive. I went back stage where he was playing and got into an argument with somebody. It must have been around '37 or '36 I guess. Oh there was another famous writer there called Ian Mag, he was backstage too, and that was — there was a record had come out with Benny Carter playing alto on this record called "Apologies." And he started out with a sort of growl on the alto you know. And I said something about this growl. And Ian says, "You growl on a trumpet, Stanley, or a trombone, not on a saxophone." And Fats said, "You can growl on any instrument if you know how." It was a splendid, just — so well I'm buying records all this time, and my friends and I decided we couldn't get — they weren't issuing enough. We started to import them from I remember for some reason, a record store called Royer Smith in Philadelphia, who sent us the catalogues. And so they were expensive as it was, because we had to pay duty on

then I think the next, oh it would be '37, a friend and I gathered up the money to go to New York the cheapest way possible on the Queen Mary, you know, right in the front of this big old ship which was about 40 pounds round trip or something you know.

MR: Wow. Was it third class?

SD: Yes it was the lowest class. We didn't want to waste any money on that. But it was rather regrettable because it was very rough, and if you're in the front of the nose, it comes down and as it hits the waves — I was in bed for two or three days there. And we were a day late getting into New York. But it played out very well because it was just the height of — almost the height of the Swing Era, '37. I heard, in three weeks I heard eighteen big bands of quality. And I was rather disgusted I remember because I didn't hear Andy Kirk's band. I didn't hear Bob Crosby's, I didn't hear Red Norvo's band. But I heard all the others, one way or the other.

MR: You did pretty well.

SD: You know, Benny Goodman was a big shot and a big deal then, and I heard Duke at the —

MR: Let me ask you something about, right at the beginning you said the pop music, when you were in boarding school and most of your friends were bringing back pop records. Can you describe what it was, pop music, at that time?

SD: Well it was dance music a lot of it. It was very square dance music. There were singers, just like today, pop singers today, and at that time comedy songs were very big. I don't think there's as much of that today. But they were popular. Some of them helped ease relations, you know, the lyrics with them.

MR: Was Paul Whiteman part of that?

SD: Paul Whiteman was — Paul Whiteman was reasonably popular. But I don't think that meant quite as much in Europe as it did in the U.S. When you consider the '30s you've got to consider the big influence of radio. I mean what people could hear on radio was so very influential you know. I mean we didn't have — in England we had English bands playing on the radio, fairly corny most of them. But here, I mean reputations were made I mean Earl Hines at the Grand Terrace in Chicago, he was heard from the midwest west, because he was an ally to the New York Paramount. That was very important. And then of course Duke Ellington, the Cotton Club in New York — the broadcast out of there was very important. That was — radio always we're stressing from the '30s because that was so important in selling records and everything, and building reputations.

MR: Do you think it was necessary for England and actually some of the United States to be introduced to jazz through the white bands first? And then start to be able to accept what Ellington and some—

SD: Well jazz hadn't sort of — jazz had been a novelty rather in Europe. But once you got into the 30s, you had these big ones coming, Fats Waller here, and Duke and I remember Lunceford came before World War II. I missed him. Calloway, Cab Calloway I think toured. And then of course there had been jazz musicians like Sidney Bechet and Tommy Ladnier and Lord Hopkins. They'd been to Europe with different groups and shows and things like that. But when I got to New York in '37, I'd been writing for the French magazine, Hugh Panassie's magazine, *Jazz Hot*. And I had an introduction to one of their American correspondents, Helen Oakley, who was making records for Irving Mills at that time. And so that was a very big part of my visit, that at night I could go out and hear the bands that was at the Savoy Ballroom and places like that. In the afternoon I could go to her record session, which was a very — she'd come from Chicago and she knew the scene much better than I did of course.

MR: Did you have aspirations to be a writer before you got into the music?

SD: No. No. My father had several business operations of different kinds and when I left school he sent my older sister to Oxford, and he said, "I think you should go." And I said, "Why?" He said, "Well you could get a good job, you could get in the church maybe." You know I said, "Oh?" It suggested a lot of security there. But I said, "No, no I don't think I need" — I hated school, and I didn't want any more education because I said I don't need that to come in this business, I can do arithmetic very well, that's all I need. Well of course I was very foolish. I missed out — I mean where writing was concerned I began writing, you know, opinion really in the French magazine, which was published in French and in English. So I made the most of that.

MR: Looks good on your resume, right?

SD: I could always read French you know, but I could never speak it well. But then I was going to come back to New York, but in 1939 I saw Ellington again. They didn't play London. I think by that time there was the struggle between the two unions you know. The British union felt British bands should come here in reciprocation. The American union didn't want them. But Duke played in Paris.

MR: Let me ask you about that. Because I thought it was the other way around, that the British union didn't want the American bands coming.

SD: No. Well the American union was in a much stronger position. There were only — the only band with any international recognition in England was Jack Hylton's. I don't think any other really had much of a name before Word War II. I mean Ambrose had a good band but they hadn't anybody that would be known in America. Whereas in England and Europe, they knew many of these American bands, and they'd been playing there. I mean I remember I also heard Hal Kemp's band. I think Bunny Berigan was in that band and I

Duke played in Paris I remember going there. That was when I first met Django, when we had a record session under Rex Stewart's name, which came out very well. But then there was six rather bleak years while the war lasted before I could come back. And my wife being an OSS and had gone to Africa and Italy and — my wife-to-be that is — I had to come back in 1946 to pursue my suit you see. But it was a rather confusing time because it changed so much.

MR: What was your involvement in World War II?

SD: In 1935 I joined the Royal Observer Corps. And I was in that until 1945. It was attached to the RAF. We were — there was immense air traffic in England after the Battle of Britain. We joined the Royal Observer Corps because we thought we could get out of the infantry and go into it, but we were stuck where we were. We had radio equipment and the light anti-aircraft, but our main job was positioning. It had been German planes, but the hedge hopping defeated radar. The radar was fine when they were up a bit, but if they came in hedge hopping, that's where you had to have visual aid. And then of course after the Americans came in and the volume of air traffic multiplied enormously. You not only had to know where they were, you had to know how many. And so that's what I did for a long time. There was not opportunities to hear jazz. Although of course we were sort of liaison with the Americans, and I was in East England in East Anglia which was just full of air fields, they were practically touching each other. I mean we used to go to the American air bases where I could hear V-disks and things like that, and catch up a bit. But not, you know — so when I got back to New York in 1946, bebop had begun. They turned their backs to the audience and would go off when they finished their solo you know, and have a smoke and then come back. And it was — it struck me as very rude, and I didn't like it. And then I remember we went to hear Jazz at the Philharmonic. And you know it was strange — then, at that time, the reaction seemed hysterical. They were wild with excitement. And yet recently they issued a Jazz at the Philharmonic made in Germany in 1956 I think it was, and the reception is just the same — it's like a football crowd. Everybody as he comes on, wild cheering you know.

MR: I think I heard that — with Lester Young on it?

SD: Yeah, it's quite recent. Well that was different you know. This is a different audience and element. I mean you'd go to the Savoy Ballroom or places like that, there would be applause. But it wasn't hysterical in the way it seemed to me. But fortunately, we turned to Ellington. He did a concert while I was there, it was the "Deep South Suite," and that sort of confirmed to me that the battle wasn't lost. So after that we agreed to be married, and Helen came to England and we lived there about twelve years.

MR: Did you two meet on your first visit?

MR: The Ellington of that time, of the '30s, he was really doing something very new. Do you think people responded to the swing part of his music, or was it the compositions themselves that really were very new?

SD: Well it was — I mean he had a much more varied program or book than the other bands. There was everything they had really. Certainly it was superior, and he had very excellent soloists. But of course what Helen was mostly doing was they were recording — Irving Mills had two labels, one a regular price, like Victor or Columbia, and the other one, Variety, was a cheaper one, thirty-five cents I think at retail. And they were recording all small units of Duke's bands and other small bands that she put together. And they were very successful too, on the juke boxes. I mean that was another factor that belongs to the thirties, very naturally you had the radio and juke boxes. After World War II they both faded in importance really. And of course television really hasn't been much help, has it? So where did we go — well during the twelve years we lived in England, there were various people came over that we saw: Mary Lou Williams and Helen will tell you how Duke came to play there at the Leeds Festival, where he was presented to the Queen. And then one night, it was at a party at a village called Felsted, where the head of British Decca, he had a house and he was at the party and we were drinking. And by this time I was pretty disgusted with what was happening with jazz, because there was, well what his labels were issuing, he had three or four different labels, and he was issuing Dixieland, or bebop. Nothing in between. This is when I'm credited with coining the term "mainstream." And so I'm telling him, "You don't have any mainstream jazz — it's very painful all this Dixieland." And so William Burrows Whithead had quite a lot to drink as I remember, and I thought that's the end of that. The next morning he called me from London and he said, "You're quite right you know." And in the 30s, he'd sent a famous British musician called Spike Hughes to New York to make records, and he made some very good ones with Coleman Hawkins, Benny Carter, and people like that. So now he says, "Who can we send to New York, to make one of these mainstream jazz?" So I'd just sold a business of my father's and I was kind of free, and I said well I could go. Well I'd been on a lot of record dates, but I'd never produced any you know. But I was trying to get a free trip, and to record some of the music. So I was sent there to make seven LPs. I forget how much the money was, but by today's standards it would be nonsense. But Decca had an arrangement with Victor that we would record with them. So the recording was done at Victor, and I was fortunate in a way that it coincided with the arrival of stereo. This was '57 — '58. And these were almost the first records made in stereo — jazz records made in stereo actually.

MR: And you said they were LPs? They weren't ten inch records? They were —

MR: The twelve inch LPs.

SD: But that was just when stereo was coming in. And these engineers were full of jargon, and it didn't mean a thing to me, I just wanted a good monaural record. So the mainstream thing was a good, commercial slogan. That gave them something new to talk about.

MR: It was a buzz word.

SD: But the records did reasonably well. There was beginners luck in part too, because some, where my heart was really in, didn't come out so well, but others came out very well. So I go back and these are issued in Europe, with quite good reviews etcetera. And the following year, my wife never really got used to the English climate, and then we were living in a house that was 400 years old you know. And of course the property after World War II in England was at a premium. My father's house opposite where we lived was 500 years old. But I was accustomed to that. So we decided to move to Connecticut where her father had a place. And he offered us a house sort of rent free. And I thought my wife and I can start up again. For Decca, I had to make I think it was two more albums for Decca. And I'd previously made one with Dickie Wells, the trombone player, and three other trombones, four trombones and a rhythm section, which was unusual but was successful and I made a number of those. And the other one I was counting on to do when Duke's manager came to me one day and said, "I hear you're making some more records." I said yes. "Then why not use my guys — our guys." I said, "Oh Duke doesn't want that." He said, "Yeah, those guys need the money." So I said, "Well can I have Johnny Hodges?" He says, "Yeah, you can have Johnny Hodges, you can just give him another name." And so I knew I couldn't have Duke, you know, so Billy Strayhorn could play piano. And that's how that album came about, which is rather a fixed subject in — I don't know whether you've read Hasse's book, well you know it's completely misinterpreted, it's as though I was trying to pull a fast one because I knew exactly that Johnny Hodges was a close friend of mine and I knew very well that he was under contract to Norman Granz you know. And then that was the end of Decca and those two. And then in the first batch, one of the things that led to more activity was Earl Hines, another of my idols. He was in San Francisco and I hadn't the time or the money to go out there, but a Belgian friend of mind was going out and I got him to record a session, which was very successful. And then after a time I had an English friend who was recording, called Dennis Preston, he made quite a few records for him which were issued on English Columbia. And I started to write. I wrote for various jazz magazines — when I had a year when I was the jazz critic of the *New York Herald Tribune*, which was bad, that was a terrible job really. You'd go to Carnegie Hall and you'd have to leave before

the concert ends, and you'd get down there and you've got to write the piece in about 20 minutes.

MR: To hit the deadline.

SD: And at the time I'd have to stay in a hotel overnight. But most were not much money. But I can't remember how, but I had a long period that was on the *Saturday Review* before that closed down. That was taken over by *Psychology Today* and they soon messed the magazine up you know, it was a shame. And I wrote for *Music Journal* for about twelve years. And you know then there were various magazines like doing interviews for *Down Beat* and jazz magazines, which subsequently I put into these books you see. So we struggled along that way.

MR: We struggled along? Was it ever — was it a good way to make a living for you?

SD: No. Oh no. Because, no I mean there's not great money in it. Not in writing. Of the four worlds I did — *The World of Duke Ellington* was the only one that made any real money. Not that it's any better than the other three, but the thing is that it has the bigger name to it. The one on Earl Hines had a full page review by James Baldwin, but it still was the least seller you know. No, if you were going to try to make a living in that field, that's why so many of them end up working for record companies. But you've just got to put a lot of little things together.

MR: Let me ask you about when you came over to make those first records. Did you have the freedom to say, to pick the artist and say all right, I want to do Coleman Hawkins? Did you then let him pick the rhythm section?

SD: Well you have to — there's give and take there. You say I want so-and-so. Then they'll say well I want so-and-so. And you've got to keep good will on both sides. Later I made an album for Camden with a big band, led by Andy Gibson, a very good arranger. And what we wanted to do was make the whole side of the album one number, just big swing thing. And it was a band I guess of about fifteen pieces. And then this band has been in the profession for oh probably thirty years at that time, and they knew everything, they knew, they had friends too. And then there are musicians that have done them favors, have had them on records, and they want to repay that by looking to feature themselves. So you end up with, very often, well in that case you might end up with one or two people you wouldn't have hired, but you more or less are obliged to. But generally, they more or less reflected what I wanted.

MR: When you got to the end of a take, was it your call to decide that you needed to do another?

SD: Both of you. Both of you. Very often you could, very often if you were a little bit in doubt, you'd say, "Do you want to make another," and they may say yeah, or he might

MR: How much time did you usually have in the studio?

SD: Well see the — three hour sessions, 15 minutes of music. That's what you're entitled to. But if you where like I did, I'd pay a half an hour overtime, which would entitle me to another five minutes of music. So I did three and a half hours of music, and you were then entitled to use 20 minutes of music, which is one side of an LP.

MR: Ah, so the 15 minutes that might have gone on a side of a record was simply because that's all the recording time you had.

SD: A three hour session is standard, and the union allowed you to use 15 minutes from that.

MR: Oh I didn't realize it was so regimented like that.

SD: I mean you could use 12 minutes if you like. But the maximum was 15. And by doing the extra half an hour, you'd get enough — you wanted about 20 for an LP side you see.

MR: Gee the union was really quite strong.

SD: Well I don't think we needed to have been as careful as we were about that. When it got back to England, some of the performances were edited down because we'd gotten a little more time than we should have had, but I don't think we needed to have done that. I don't think the union has time to check all those you know. But the company didn't want any trouble there. It wasn't because of the artists. But subsequently I made a lot of records for Dennis Preston's label in England, English Columbia. And by this time I was getting sort of involved with Ellington, when Doubleday finally agreed with him to do *Music is my Mistress*, his book. Doubleday was up at the Rainbow Grill and Tope says to Duke, "Well it's high time we had your book, Mr. Ellington." And Duke said, "Well how much, Mr. Doubleday?" And he said something, I forget how much it was, but it seemed a lot of money at the time, $50,000 or something like that. And he said, "Well yeah, we'll do it" he said, "if Stanley will work with me on it." And so I was the ghost you know, which was very good because it meant that I traveled around with him quite a lot. And my contribution was not really — well it was sort of rephrasing some things, but as far as possible, it was just as he said it you know. But I had to program it.

MR: Why did Ellington trust you?

SD: Because I guess he realized I was harmless. No, but I mean by this time well he knew my wife from way back, and her brother through, they used to play bridge together. And I think you know, I used to go to all his record sessions and everything, and he just got accustomed to my face.

MR: Sounds like a song title.

SD: Yeah, well, I thought it might.

MR: You were present during the "Afro-Bossa" recording also?

SD: Yes.

MR: Ellington had like huge ears, right? I mean he just absorbed things from places he traveled.

SD: Yeah. Well I mean I always remember once when we were driving to Chicago, we'd stop at a sort of diner or something. He'd listen, he'd be very conscious of what was being played on those juke boxes. And he'd ask kids, "Who's your favorite band" and things like that. And he was very attuned to — he was a much wiser man than the average person. He had sort of basic wisdom there. And of course these, when the LP started, the LP was a boom in a way, because everybody talks about Ellington's extended works. Because they're longer not better. That's the European symphonic thinking really. They think his extended works are the most important. And so when he starts to do suites, they don't realize that a suite is almost a connection of assorted sort of dances really. That's what it was way back in Tudor times. So a suite is an extended work. But that's still just a collection of short pieces, like they'd always been doing. And it was a very good thing, because those longer works were, there was some marvelous music in them. But that wasn't any more important than what was going into the suites. Why did you ask about "Afro-Bossa?" Because that's one of my — that in my opinion, is a very good album. But if you notice, everybody talks of the later period of Ellington. They always talk of the "Far East Suite." Now why, I don't know. I mean the "Afro" the "Afro-Eurasian Eclipse" and "Afro-Bossa," these have much more original work.

MR: Yeah, and also I think from what I've listened to is it was one of the first times that the extra percussion had a place in the music.

SD: Well then of course he did the Latin, the — what was to have been the "Mexican Anticipation" when we went round South America with him, and when we came back then we went to Mexico and he promised to do a Mexican suite. And he was writing that as we traveled round Mexico. He would play a concert — I remember we played a concert in Mexico City and the next morning we left very early in the morning on a DC-3, you know, remember those old planes? Twin engine? Dakotas. And we'd fly out in that, and then we'd play an outdoor thing in a big arena, the plane was an hour late so part of the audience had gone, and the amplification was awful. They can't mic, sort of, the bass, and the trombones were amplified enormously and the saxophones — you could hardly hear. But the crowd thought it was splendid you know. Well then we finished that and go back to the hotel, and he's going to continue writing the "Mexican Anticipation" suite. That's how he did it — writing all the time that he's traveling, no matter what the hours. Then he found there was no room service in the hotels, so he said well we'd better go to bed. And then we'd leave the next morning. We'd get up about six o'clock. And do one of those tours was amazing. Makes you wonder how they stood that you know.

SD: Yeah. And I mean flying simply meant that instead of doing a one-nighter and a bus from city to city, you flew from one city in one country to a city in another country. And you'd have to go through customs, and funny money and all that stuff.

MR: So it wasn't that much better with the advent of the airplane.

SD: Well it did sort of open up the world, I mean, bigger markets surely.

MR: Did Ellington write without a piano?

SD: Yes. Oh yes.

MR: He just could hear it.

SD: He naturally preferred to have one. But he did, yeah.

MR: I guess there's that story about him and writing "Mood Indigo" in such short order.

SD: Well you know a lot of those things come out, too, of what he is when there. Sort of they don't do much rehearsing. The rehearsals, even when they're trying to make a new recording like the one that's based on John Steinbeck's book, "Sweet Thursday," I remember them doing that in Boston. And they were playing in the hotel. And he each night, they would have new bits of music to drop in the middle of the program, when there was rehearsal. But I remember there was a number that he was doing that piece, that's where he explained the story to me, which is he would be in the shower, and he would think of something, and get out of the shower and go and alter something on the score and get back in the shower. You don't lose things that way you know.

MR: In your experience watching that band from night to night, I've heard that they weren't real consistent in their performances — that they could be on and off at a moment's notice.

SD: Well the musicians say that. They say that it was often sloppy. Well undoubtedly there were occasions you see when somebody was tired and disagreeable, and a soloist could be way under par. That's undoubtedly true. But you know it's amazing how all these records, live performances have come out that were taken from broadcasts and things. They don't really show up very much you know. I think some of it was jealousy on the part of other musicians. And even envy, you know, where there were so many guys that would have given anything to be in that band, and they were never asked or they would even — may have approached and been turned down. This is one way of getting it out.

MR: Was there a difference in sound, to your ears, between most of the white bands and most of the black big bands?

SD: Yes. Yes. I think so. I think in a sense, and you might say in the early days, the white bands were a bit more polished, but they didn't swing. You know, that was really, I mean when Basie's band comes out of Kansas City and there's a sensation, George Simon, the critic said it was out of tune and everything. And well they were playing with instruments

of course a lot of those musicians didn't have the education that white musicians had had. They were probably not good readers to start with. So that was why Basie's thing stressed head arrangements, which they sort of cooked up themselves. But you know if you take the best black bands of the swing era, from the point of swinging they are undoubtedly very much superior. But you can take Goodman's band, it's probably the best of the white bands, Artie Shaw's, Glenn Miller's, Tommy Dorsey had a very good band. But in my opinion, I think there was a big difference. But on the other hand you have to take into consideration the way white musicians, you can play and think perhaps more in tune with the white audience. You know that's more, you've got a sound thing there that is more applicable to what white ears are accustomed to. Certainly I mean I can remember my father and mother when they had the plunger muted trumpet and trombone. In Duke's band they thought that was crazy. The other thing, the other two things I will tell you would be I mentioned Earl Hines in '64 I think it was, my friend Dan Morgenstern and his friend David Himmelstein, they got to the Little Theater in New York, and there was an Israeli company playing there. And they couldn't play on a Saturday or Sunday or something. And Dan and David had got this theater where they could perform jazz. And they opened with Coleman Hawkins and had a big success. And we were talking afterwards and they said, about whom they should have next, and I said well why don't you get Earl Hines, he'd been through the previous winter with a rather poor little band. I said bring him in and have him play a lot of piano. And they said "would he come?" And I said well I could try. I'd been in touch with him for years, because I had a friend in San Francisco who used to send me records of his broadcasts, and then he used to send me, he had a radio program and he'd tape it. Instead of sending me a letter he'd tape the thing and send it and usually play a number on it, so I knew he was still wonderful. So he came and played a concert in the Little Theater which was a sensation. And it got splendid publicity in New York — Whitney Balliet put it up in the *New Yorker* and then he made records with Columbia and Victor. And then he was off — he went to Russia for the State Department and for the rest of his life — oh when he went to Russia, he said, "While I'm away, will you take care of any business coming in?" And I always remember we were in a hotel room he took me. He was from Chicago, and he took a gun out of his pocket dropped it across the bed and said, "You better keep this, I better not take that on the State Department tour." It was loaded, too. So after that I became like his unofficial manager. And you know he made — oh he must have made about thirty albums before he died, and he proved himself, no question about that. I mean he was unlike some of the other famous record makers, he was a genuine improviser. Most things were one take you know.

SD: Well you see that actually worked against him. Because here's a man who made his name really in 1928. He made "Weather Bird" with Louis and "West End Blues" which are two of the most famous records in jazz history. So people think, would automatically think of him as being old fashioned, because he was of the '20s. But he revolutionized piano playing, and he always asked people, other pianists, he said, "How do you do that?" And if they asked him how he did it, he would always show them. And he incorporated new things — the one book, I don't know, did you read that recent book by Teddy Wilson? It's worth reading, if you've got it in your library there. He tells what makes Earl's style distinctive, in a way nobody else had. It's very good. What else did I do? Oh, one other thing. They were having some revival of Basie in George Wein's thing at Carnegie Hall. I said they should — they had a meeting where we all put up ideas, and I said "well you ought to get back his best singer — Helen Humes." And for some reason I was in Louisville and I went and spent the night talking to her and practically persuaded her to come back. She had more or less retired. When her mother died she'd been working in a munitions factory and playing bingo, and was very happy. But she came back as a result of that. And she enjoyed — she was another bright talent that's been forgotten. She was very successful for about ten years I think.

MR: I'm going to let Tim —

SD: How's the time running?

MR: We're just about — we'll wrap up here. I'm going to let Tim flip our cassette so that we don't lose anything.

I see you also have won a couple of awards — A Grammy note for Duke Ellington.

SD: Yes that was the first Grammy for liner notes. I shared that with Leonard Feather. Yeah, he wrote half of it, I wrote the other.

MR: When you wrote these books, the Count Basie and, the conversations you had with the musicians, I notice your questions aren't here. You just left out your questions and basically let them talk. Was there much editing you had to do for this work?

SD: Well the editing had to do, you have to put the material in an order. You know, because you sit for two hours talking to a guy, while he remembers something, he says oh but— so you've got to bring this back. And I think the interviews which are question and answer are very tiring to read. I think the interviewer should be out of it as much as possible. I think it's a waste of space, and the reader's attention really.

MR: Good advice. What do you think of the state of jazz today? It has been kind of elevated to an art form. It's been institutionalized in colleges and so forth. Do you think it's a positive thing for the music?

SD: Well it's hard, I don't know, it's very hard to say I think. You see one of the things that

fact that people were dancing to it. And the musicians all liked that, most of them liked it because you know, they are not, it isn't quite the same thing as an audience sitting down where you've got to — I mean that's why the tempos are so bad on many of those Jazz at the Philharmonic, because the tempos are too fast and they're just tricks — flamboyant things. You notice how often they'll repeat a little catchy phrase, and they know this, it's not really clever but it gets a big hand. It's a different thing. Well I mean I don't know that of course rock & roll comes along and takes away — the kids are dancing to rock & roll, partly because jazz had become so ambitious that it wasn't very danceable. You could dance to it but it didn't make you want to dance. I think that's an important difference you know.

MR: I like that word "ambitious" that you just used.

SD: Well it is, isn't it? Even today. There's a new book called *The History of Jazz* by Ted Gioia. Well the first half of it takes you up to the end of the Swing Era and I can understand that, and he's done a good job. Then when he goes into the rest of the history of jazz, you get bebop, but the later period it seems as though you could do anything and if it's different, it's good. But that's not true you know.

MR: If it's new then it's justifiable.

SD: Yeah.

MR: I've often felt that jazz has moved too fast for its own good.

SD: Definitely.

MR: You know? Like Miles was a perfect example. As soon as he had people with him, he was off somewhere else.

SD: And then I mean to more or less end up with compromising his world was rather a sign of defeat to my mind. I mean that was a matter of money you could say, but I don't think it was purely money with him, I think it was kind of desperation.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating hour for me. And on behalf of jazz lovers everywhere, I'd like to thank you for your output over the years.

SD: Well thank you very much.

MR: Your involvement in the music — it's been great to have someone who's been able to gather all the stories of these musicians.

SD: Well just tell me, before I hand it over to Helen, just tell me what is the archive planning to do then, beside these interviews?

MR: We will, as we plan our guidelines, we're officially opening in October.

SD: Oh, I see.

MR: But we're not open yet. But it will be a place, somewhat like Rutgers, where you can visit, and researchers and students and authors can view the interviews, read the

SD: Where abouts are you?

MR: We're in Central New York. We're right near Syracuse, outside Syracuse.

SD: Oh, I see, up there, yeah.

MR: And I would like to set up a program where other music schools could borrow our tapes much like a library. Now we're treading a line here with keeping the musicians so that they don't feel like they're being taken advantage of you know. But we've amassed a nice collection of things, and it's been a real honor for me to actually meet so many musicians.

SD: Well are you sort of thinking of accumulating stuff like Rutgers?

MR: Yes. We hope to start a collection of LP's and photographs from, especially the musicians we've talked to, and we've made a small start on that. And in support of the interviews it would be nice to have material like that.

SD: Yeah. I sent a large part of my — I sent photographs, magazines, and LPs to Yale. And that was partly to raise some scratch. But also, you know, the house is reasonable so I spent — it's amazing how it accumulates you know, the books and stuff. But the magazines are a problem, aren't they.

MR: Yeah, they are. They take up a lot of space and you know they deteriorate.

SD: Yeah well I had *Down Beat* I remember complete, and that went to Yale, and *Metronome* I had the best years of. But that's something you'll have to face eventually.

MR: Well thanks for your time.

SD: You're very welcome.